

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*The Gospel of Life ~
The Gospel According to Robin Wall Kimmerer
October 12, 2025*



Patch of moss photographed on Denman Island in B.C. by Billyshiverstick

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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Childcare & Children's Programming at First Church

FCCLA offers childcare and children's programming during service for all ages — from infants through youth. For more information or to register your child, please stop by the First Kids First check-in table in the entrance to the Cathedral, or follow the signs in the hallway through the middle doors of the Sanctuary.

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on BEACH SPRING and ST. DENIO

Sonata in F Major (Carlos Seixas)

– Allegro – Giga – Minuet

Psalm 91 "Qui habitat" (Luys Alberto)

Entr'acte II and Toreador Grand March from *Carmen* (Georges Bizet)

Recuerdos de la Alhambra (Francisco Tárrega)

Sonata in C Major (Carlos Seixas)

– Allegro

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Yulia Fox & Rev. Fregin

In the dominant story, humanity is the pinnacle, the crown of creation. But indigenous wisdom whispers otherwise: we are the younger siblings of this great family, the latecomers to the long dance of life.

The trees have been here far longer than we, singing praise with every breath they give.

The waters repeat rhythms of renewal.

The birds carry songs older than our languages.

Let us draw near with humility, open to all the teachers that surround us—
the rooted, the winged, the finned, the furred.

Let us enter this time to listen, and to let go of our common tendencies toward domination,
not to claim superiority, but to join a chorus of gratitude.

*Come, younger siblings, children of God and of earth.
Come, and let us learn together the wisdom of creation
and our common connection with all that is.
Come, for the Spirit gathers us from near and far.*

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

For Beauty Meadows

ST. DENIO

For beauty of meadows, for grandeur of trees
For flowers of woodlands, for creatures of seas,
For all you created and gave us to share,
We praise you, Creator, extolling your care.

As stewards of beauty received at your hand,
As creatures who hear your most urgent command,
We turn from our wasteful destruction of life,
Confessing our failures, confessing our strife.

Teach us once again to be gardeners in peace;
All nature around us is ours but on lease;
Your name would hallow in all that we do,
Fulfilling our calling, creating with you.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Creator God, Great Spirit, we give our thanks for the opportunity to gather in this sacred space.

Here we are most aware of the gift of wind:

and the four directions from which it comes.

Here we are most aware of the gift of sun:

and the four directions on which it shines.

Here we are most aware of the gift of humanity:

and the four directions in which we exist.

Here we are most aware of the gift of Creation:

and the four directions which support our living, breathing, and being.

This day we honor all the Indigenous people of the Earth,
and we commit ourselves to be people of reconciliation in the tradition of the Christ.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Halcyon Days"

MELISSA DUNPHY

Cathedral Choir, Tanner Pfeiffer, *Conductor*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Yulia Fox

Great Spirit, our Creator, who is in all places,

Sacred is your name.

May your wisdom guide us,

Your will be done in our lives, as it is throughout Creation.

Provide for us today the nourishment we need,

And forgive us our wrongs, as we forgive those who have wronged us.

Lead us on the path of understanding and respect,

And protect us from ignorance and harm.

For you are the source of all power, beauty, and love,

From generation to generation, forever and always. Amen.

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

Happiness doesn't lie in conspicuous consumption and the relentless amassing of useless things.
Happiness lies in the person sitting beside you and your ability to talk to them.
Happiness is clear-headed human interaction and empathy. Happiness is home. And home is not
a house – home is a mythological concept. It is a state of mind. A place of communion and
unconditional love. It is where, when you cross its threshold, you finally feel at peace.

[DennisLehane]

This morning in this sacred place we call home,
may the peace of God be with you.

And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from our Religious Tradition *from the Psalms*

Yulia Fox

O Great Love, our Beloved,
How powerful is your Name
 in all the earth!
You, whose glory is sung in heaven
 by the angels and the saints,
You, who with the innocence and
 spontaneity of a child,
confound those who are mighty
 and proud,
You quiet the unloving and fearful.

When I look up at the heavens
 at the work of Love's creation,
 at the infinite variety of your Plan;
who are we that you rejoice and delight in us?
 You have made us in your image,
 You fill us with your Love;
 You have made us co-creators of
 the earth!
 guardians of the planet!
 to care for all your creatures.
 to tend the land, the sea,
 and the air we breathe;
 all that You have made.
 You have placed it in our hands.

O Great Love, our Beloved,
How powerful is your Name in
 all the earth!

[nanmerrill/adptlvf]

For the Word of God in Scripture,
for the Word of God among us,
for the Word of God within us.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

O Great Spirit, whose voice we hear in the winds,
and whose breath gives life to all the world,
hear us.
When we feel small and weak,
we need your strength and wisdom.
Let us walk in beauty
and make our eyes ever behold
the red and purple sunset.
Make our hands respect the things you have made.
Make our ears sharp to sense your voice.
Make us wise so that we may understand
the things you have taught your people.
Let us learn the lessons you have hidden in every leaf and rock.
We seek strength,
not to be greater than another,
but to fight our worst enemy – ourselves.
Make us always ready to welcome you
with open hands and understanding that is true.
So when life fades, as the fading sunset,
our spirit may come to you.
Amen and Amen.

-Anonymous

Meditation Anthem

"Gaze Upon The Trees"
Laude

ANDREW BALFOUR

"Love is like a waterfall that happens in the spring when the snow has melted in the mountains and rushes to the sea. Noopimiing, noopimiing [in the forest]. And just you happened on it when you walked out in the forest just to gaze upon the trees, Mitigoog, mitigoog [trees]. And you find a wisp of loveliness floating in the magic and the leaves." ~Duke Redbird

Sermon

The Gospel According to Robin Wall Kimmerer

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

We come to this table
hoping to reweave the unraveling fabric of our world
and reconnect once more with the larger family of creation.
To find once more that place of calm.
To remind ourselves that we belong.
And to remember what it is we belong to.

We come to center ourselves,
to open ourselves,
to remember ourselves,
and to celebrate the life we share together. [adapt/myoung]

We take this bread, we break it and we bless it,
remembering that Jesus invited all to their table
and it is for us – the bread of new life.

We take this cup, we pour it and we bless it,
remembering at that this table all are welcome
and this cup is for us – the cup of hope.

Let us pray...

Prayer of Blessing

O God, we know
that this food we are about to share
has already been blessed...
by you,
by those who planted it,
by those who tended it,
by those who gathered it,
by those who prepared it.

*So bless us, O God,
that we may taste and know
its blessedness,
as we feast with one another
at this table you have prepared.
Amen and amen.*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Each week in our time together,
we are offered an invitation into the mystical.

Consider this: every spiritual system has an
understanding of healing the Earth.

Some express it very organically, through kinship,
others envision it philosophically, through stewardship.

But however it is articulated:
all of our faiths point us toward healing our planet.
I believe that tells us something.

We are all being pointed in the same direction.
Peace and unity are possible.
Healing is possible.
We can find them in our shared love of the Earth.
As a global family, we have a common Mother.

[Fr. Steve Charleston]

Offertory

"Ambe"
Cathedral Choir

ANDREW BALFOUR

"Come in, all people, there is good life here."

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Prayer of Offering

Yulia Fox

Great Spirit, Glorious Creator,
we celebrate our lives and this world.

We are blessed with so many gifts:
the circle of loved ones,
and those far and wide.

The food we have for sharing
and for those who provide it.

*This place we name home,
and all life that surrounds us.*

This time, which we have been given
to flourish in your love.

*We rejoice in this abundance
and we give thanks for your grace.*

This morning, Spirit of God,
fill our hearts with joy
as we share these, our gifts,
for the well-being and healing of your creation.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

Know the ways of the ones who take care of you, so that you may take care of them.
Introduce yourself. Be accountable as the one who comes asking for life.
Ask permission before taking. Abide by the answer.
Never take the first. Never take the last.
Take only what you need. Take only that which is given.
Never take more than half. Leave some for others.
Harvest in a way that minimizes harm.
Use it respectfully. Never waste what you have taken. Share.
Give thanks for what you have been given.
Give a gift, in reciprocity for what you have taken.
Sustain the ones who sustain you and the earth will last forever.

[Robin Wall Kimmerer, from *The Serviceberry*]

Choral Response

"Prayer Song"
Cathedral Choir, Tanner Pfeiffer, *Soloist*

RUSSELL WALLACE

"Thank you. Bless us. Gather us together."

***Hymn for the Journey**

Restless Weaver

BEACH SPRING

Restless Weaver, ever spinning threads of justice and shalom;
Dreaming patterns of creation where all creatures find a home;
Gathering up life's varied fibers – every texture, every hue:
Grant us your creative vision, with us weave your world anew.

Where earth's fragile web is unraveling, help us mend each broken strand.
Bless our urgent, bold endeavors cleansing water, air, and land.
Through the Spirit's inspiration – offering health where once was pain –
Strengthen us to be the stewards of your world knit whole again.

When our violent lust for power ends in lives abused and torn,
From compassion's sturdy fabric fashion hope and trust reborn.
Where injustice rules as tyrant, give us courage, God, to dare
Live our dreams of transformation. Make our lives incarnate prayer.

Restless Weaver, still conceiving new life – now and yet to be –
Binding all your vast creation in one living tapestry:
You have called us to be weavers. Let your love guide all we do.
With your Reign of Peace our pattern, we will weave your world anew.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Toreador Grand March from *Carmen* - Reprise (Georges Bizet)

Inside The Music

"Monday our country celebrates Indigenous People's Day, and we will be guided by Indigenous composers in our gathering this week. Andrew Balfour is a Canadian composer of Cree descent. We have enjoyed a number of his pieces, including "Ambe," which is one of the choir's favorites to sing. He describes the steady beat as representing the heartbeat of Mother Earth. As the choir pulses with the earth, the sopranos introduce a rising line that he says "conveys the powerful totem of the eagle which represents the teaching of love, wisdom, and strength." We will also hear a new piece of Balfour's this week in "Gaze Upon The Trees." It feels like a moment alone in nature when you have given yourself a break from technology and the need to please others, and have come into connection with yourself through the grace of the earth. The poet, Redbird, reminds us in the first words that through this calming, we feel love stir inside of us. The power of pause ripples through Balfour's slowly changing sonic tapestries. Neurologically, it is in these moments when the brain's default mode network begins to make connections that help us feel expansive, connected, and loved. So often in life we feel the need for moments, things, people to be more. This striving for other creates anxieties whose only relief comes by recalling ourselves to this moment through the power of our senses. When we awaken to awareness, our brains and bodies remind us that we are enough here and now. Russell Wallace hails from the St'at'imc and Lil'wat Nation. He wrote "Prayer Song" in collaboration with other musicians as a reflection on their time together. Its specific use of the pentatonic melody reminds our ears of other Indigenous chant from North America. Wallace has created multiple pieces whose goal it is to remind us of gratitude through song. Similar to Balfour, he offers us the gift of presence and being. In a world overwhelmed by anxiety, these gifts feel indescribably essential." ~Dr. David Harris